

BUDDHISM

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THE BUDDHIST FAITH was founded by an Indian nobleman called Gautama Siddhartha in the 6th century BC. Gautama, who became known as the Buddha, or the "Awakened One", told people how to achieve fulfilment. He taught that fulfilment is reached by meditation, wisdom, and correct behaviour in all aspects of life. Buddhists also believe in reincarnation, in other words that a person can be reborn after death. The Buddha is revered by his followers, but not worshipped as a god. For this reason, Buddhism exists side-by-side with other religions in many countries. There are probably some 320 million Buddhists worldwide, although the majority are in Asia.

Rites and ceremonies

Ceremonies at Buddhist temples are usually simple. They involve reciting extracts from Buddhist scriptures and making offerings to the Buddha. A monk may give a sermon. Some Buddhist rituals also involve candle-lit processions and music-making. The Buddhist year is enlivened with festivals, most of which take place at full Moon. The most famous festival is Wesak, at New Year, which celebrates the birth, enlightenment, and death of the Buddha.

Hand gestures on a statue of the Buddha



The Buddha touches earth as witness to his worthiness for Buddhahood.



This gesture shows the Buddha actively turning the Wheel of Law.



The Buddha reassures an approaching person.

The Buddha

Statues of the Buddha are kept in temples and homes to inspire Buddhists to live as he did. Buddhists bow before the statue to show their respect. They also carry out the ceremony called "Going for refuge", in which they recite texts that show their dedication to the Buddha, to his teaching (the Dharma), and to the community of Buddhists (the Sangha).

Teachings

The Buddha taught the Four Noble Truths, which explain the Buddhist attitude to suffering and how fulfilment can be achieved. The Truths say that suffering is always present in the world; that the human search for pleasure is the source of suffering; that it is possible to be free from these desires by achieving a state called nirvana; and that the way to nirvana is through the Eightfold Path.



Wheel of Law

Pictures in the inner circle reveal the six realms of existence.

In each realm, a Buddha-figure helps the beings there.



Three animals in the centre are symbols of ignorance.

Wheel of Life

The Eightfold Path

The Path teaches that the way Buddhists lead their lives should be correct in eight important aspects: understanding, thought, speech, action, means of livelihood (work), effort, recollection, and meditation. The eight-spoked Wheel of Law shown above represents each of the eight stages of the Path.

Karma

Buddhists believe in the law of karma. According to this law, good and bad actions result in fitting rewards and punishments, both in this life and in later rebirths. The Wheel of Life is a symbol of rebirth. When people die, they are reborn into one of its six realms of existence.

Offerings

Buddhists regularly make offerings to the Buddha, such as flowers and food. Burning incense or candles and scattering petals around the Buddha's statue are ways of making an offering that also beautifies the temple. The light of the candles is the light of the Buddha's great wisdom, and the smoke from incense wafts the truth of the doctrine towards the devotees.



Candles



Incense



Lotus flowers

Meditation

Buddhists meditate in order to purify their minds and free themselves from thoughts about material things. In this way they hope to achieve "perfect mindfulness", one of the stages in the Eightfold Path. One way in which they meditate is to concentrate on feeling their breath going in and out. This empties the mind of selfish thoughts, making the person calmer and the mind clearer.



The Buddha's topknot is a sign of his princely wisdom.

His face has the serene expression of meditation.

Long ear lobes symbolize his nobility.

Eyes cast down show that he is meditating.

Coloured sash is changed for each season.

Buddha's cross-legged position is called the lotus position.